

Your Exercise Packet

Session 1 — "Claude as your new employee" Searcy Chamber of Commerce · Thursday, August 6, 2026

By the end of today you'll be able to...

- Draft and improve real writing with Claude.
 - Get straight answers out of a long document.
 - Turn a spreadsheet into plain-English insight and a chart.
 - Set up a Project so Claude knows your business.
-

Before you start

You need two things open:

1. **Claude, logged in.** Open a browser, go to **claude.ai**, and sign in.
2. **The two sample files.** They live at one short link, and you'll go there twice today:

tinyurl.com/petalstem26

The two files are `vendor-agreement.pdf` (a contract) and `petal-and-stem-sales.csv` (a spreadsheet).

Download each one when the exercise asks for it, not before. The same link stays in the bottom-left corner of the slide both times you need it.

How this packet works. There are eight exercises, E1 through E8, in the order we'll do them. Each one has a goal, numbered steps, and a bold **Done when** line so you always know whether you're finished. Your instructor will call time — if you're not done, that's fine. Nobody is behind. Every step is written down here, so you can finish anything at home.

Keep this open in its own window or tab, next to Claude. You'll be looking back and forth all morning, and there's nothing in here you need to write on — everything you produce today lives in Claude, on your own screen.

A word on words. A *prompt* is just the thing you type into Claude. A *chat* is one conversation. A CSV is a plain spreadsheet file — the kind almost any program can save. That's the whole vocabulary.

About Dana. Some exercises use a made-up business: Petal & Stem, a flower shop on Race Street in Searcy, owned by Dana. It's fictional on purpose — that way nobody's real numbers ever go on the projector.

Block 1 — Write it

E1 — Write the thing you've been putting off

Goal: get a real piece of writing off your to-do list.

Steps

1. Look at the **left sidebar** of the screen and click **New chat**. (If you don't see a sidebar, move your mouse to the left edge of the screen and it slides out.)
2. Decide what you're actually writing. The real thing, not a practice one. Settle on it before you touch the keyboard — you're about to describe it to Claude in detail, and that's much harder if you're still deciding.
Stuck? Write a thank-you note to a customer from last week, or the reply to the email in your inbox you've been avoiding. That counts.
3. Look at the big **message box** at the bottom of the screen — the wide box you type into, with a **+** button in its lower-left corner. Click in it.
4. Type your prompt using **all six parts** of the frame below. Don't press Enter until all six are in there. It's longer than feels natural. That's the point.

- | | |
|------------------|--|
| 1. Who I am | – business, what kind, what town |
| 2. What I want | – the actual thing: a post, an email, an ad |
| 3. The facts | – dates, prices, deadlines it can't possibly guess |
| 4. How it sounds | – warm, plain, funny, professional. Your call. |
| 5. How long | – "under 80 words" |
| 6. How many | – "give me three versions" |

Don't copy those six lines in. They're a checklist of what to include, not the words to type. Write yours as normal sentences, the way you'd explain the job to a person standing in front of you.

5. Press **Enter**. Read what comes back.

If you hit Enter before you were done, don't start over. Just type the rest in the next message. Claude keeps the whole thread in mind.

Done when: three versions are on your screen and at least one of them is close to something you'd actually send.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *rewrite my favorite version for a customer who has never heard of us*. Same facts, different reader — see how much changes.

E2 — Make it yours (push it three times)

Goal: stop accepting first drafts. This is the habit that separates people who use this from people who tried it once.

Steps

1. Look at the answer already on your screen from E1. Pick the version you like best.
2. Stay in the same chat. Do **not** start over and do **not** rewrite your prompt. You're going to push it three times, the way you'd talk to a person.
3. Three moves: make it shorter, change the tone, and add something only you know. Type each one as a plain sentence, one message at a time, and read what comes back before you send the next. Dana's three looked like this:

Shorter.
Less salesy.
Add that we've been on Race Street for eleven years.

4. Your turn. Send your three, one message at a time: **push 1** is length, **push 2** is tone, **push 3** is the thing only you know — a detail about your business Claude has no way to guess. Read each answer before you send the next one.

Done when: you've sent three pushes and the version on your screen is better than the one you started with.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what questions would you ask me to make this better?* Then answer its questions and watch the next draft.

Block 2 — Read it

E3 — Ask a contract what's in it

Goal: find the three things buried in Dana's supplier contract that would cost her real money.

Steps

1. Download `vendor-agreement.pdf` from the sample files link: tinyurl.com/petalstem26
2. Click **New chat** in the left sidebar.
3. Look at the **bottom-left corner** of the box where you type. There's a **+** button down there. Not the top of the screen. Not a paperclip — there isn't one. Bottom left, inside the message box.
4. Click the **+**, choose **Add files or photos**, and pick `vendor-agreement.pdf`. (Dragging the file straight into the chat window works too, and so does pasting it.)
5. Wait until the file's name shows up attached to your message box. That's how you know it went through — don't ask your question before it does.
6. Ask these three questions, **one at a time** — send the first, read the answer, then send the second:

```
1. Explain this agreement to me in plain English, like I'm not a lawyer.
2. What am I agreeing to do, and what is the supplier agreeing to do?
3. What in here could cost me money, lock me in, or surprise me later?
   Quote the exact section.
```

7. Now the hunt. There are **three things** in this contract that would genuinely cost Dana money. Ask for them:

```
Find me the three things in this contract most likely to
cost me money that I wouldn't notice until it's too late.
```

8. Leave that answer up on your screen. In a minute you'll compare your three with the rest of the room, and it's worth seeing whether Claude handed everyone the same three.

Done when: you can name all three money problems in this contract and say which section each one is in.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *write me a short, polite email to this supplier asking to renegotiate the two worst terms.*

E4 — Now do it to one of yours

Goal: the same three questions, pointed at a document that's actually yours.

Steps

1. Find a document already on your laptop — a lease, an insurance policy, a vendor contract, an email chain you're tired of, a photo of something on paper.

2. Click **New chat**, then click the **+** in the bottom-left of the message box and choose **Add files or photos**.
3. Ask it the same three questions from E3. They work on almost anything.
4. Read the answer with your own eyes. You're still the boss.

What it will accept: PDF, Word documents (DOCX), CSV, plain text (TXT), web pages (HTML), ODT, RTF, EPUB, JSON, and images (JPEG, PNG, GIF, WebP). A photo of a paper document works fine. An Excel **.xlsx** file needs one setting turned on — see **Do this before Block 3**, just below.

Your call, and we mean it: this is your own account, but you still decide what you hand it. If today's document is your most sensitive one, pick a different document. Nothing today requires it, and nothing you upload goes on the projector.

Done when: Claude has told you something about your own document that you either didn't know or hadn't thought about.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what's missing from this document that you'd expect to see in one like it?* Gaps are as useful as gotchas.

Do this before Block 3 — the one setting

This takes twenty seconds and the next block doesn't work without it.

1. Look at the **bottom-left corner** of the screen for your **initials** in a small circle. Click them.
2. Click **Settings**.
3. Click **Capabilities**.
4. Find "**Code execution and file creation**" and make sure it's switched **on**.

Some of you will find it already on. Turn it on if it isn't. This is the switch that lets Claude make charts and build files — without it, the next block is disappointing for you specifically.

If your account came from your employer (a Team or Enterprise plan), yours may live under **Organization settings > Capabilities**, and the person who manages your accounts may have to turn it on. Tell your instructor and you'll work around it.

Done when: the "Code execution and file creation" switch reads on.

Block 3 — Count it

E5 — Ask a spreadsheet a question in English

Goal: get a spreadsheet to tell you what it means — and get a chart out of it — without touching a formula.

You do not need to know a thing about spreadsheets for this. You need to know how to ask a question.

Steps

1. Download `petal-and-stem-sales.csv` from the same sample files link (tinyurl.com/petalstem26). It's 132 orders from Dana's flower shop, January through July.
2. Click **New chat**.
3. Click the + in the bottom-left of the message box, choose **Add files or photos**, and pick `petal-and-stem-sales.csv`.
4. Ask these four, **one at a time**:

1. This is every order my shop took this year. In plain English, what should I know?
2. Which month was my best and which was my worst? What happened in each?
3. Which category brings in the most money, and which one do I sell the most of?
4. When does my wedding and event business actually happen? Give me the date range.

5. Now ask for the picture:

Make me a bar chart of sales by month.

6. Watch the right side of your screen. A panel opens there with your chart in it. That panel is called an **Artifact** — it's a separate window from the chat, where Claude puts things big enough to stand on their own. Look at its **bottom-right corner** to copy it or download it. Every artifact you make also gets collected under **Artifacts** in the left sidebar, so you don't have to dig through old chats to find it.

If your chart shows up inside the reply instead of in a panel on the right, nothing is broken. That's a newer style of chart drawn right into the response. Those aren't saved automatically, so if you want to keep one, use its "Save as artifact" or download option.

7. Your real assignment: **find something in this file that would change what Dana does next month**. Have one ready — you'll be asked for it before the block is over.

Done when: a bar chart of sales by month is on your screen and you can say one thing about this business you couldn't have seen by scrolling the rows.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *based on this, what should I do differently in the next 90 days? Give me three specific moves and what each is worth.*

E6 — Your own numbers (optional, and private)

Goal: point the same questions at your own business — *if* you want to, and *if* you have something with you.

This one is optional on purpose. Read this first:

- **Your numbers never go on the projector.** Not today, not at any point. Nobody is going to ask you to share a screen or read a figure out loud.
- **Uploading your own file is entirely your choice.** If you'd rather sit this one out and watch, that's a completely fine way to spend these few minutes. Skip to E7 and you've missed nothing.
- If your file has customer names, account numbers, or anything you'd rather not hand over, **delete that column first** — or just pick a different file.
- Don't have anything with you? Good news: this is on the homework sheet, and your kitchen table is a better place for it anyway.

Steps

1. Find a file of numbers already on this laptop: a sales export, a QuickBooks report, a spreadsheet you keep by hand.
2. **Save it as a CSV** if you can — that's the format that always works. (In Excel: File > Save As, then pick "CSV" from the file-type list.) An Excel **.xlsx** file will also work, but only if you turned on "Code execution and file creation" back in **Do this before Block 3**.
3. Click **New chat**, click the + in the bottom-left, choose **Add files or photos**, and pick your file.
4. Ask it the same four questions from E5. Then ask for a chart of whatever you're actually curious about.

One caution, and it matters: it read the file you gave it, and only the file you gave it. It doesn't know about the sale you never wrote down or the invoice you never entered. If your spreadsheet is roughly right, the answers are roughly right.

Done when: you've asked your own numbers one question in plain English and gotten an answer back — or you've decided to do this at home instead. Both count.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *what's the one number in here I should be watching every month, and why that one?*

Block 4 — Teach it your business

This is the part you take home. Everything so far, you had to explain yourself from scratch every single time. This ends that.

What's a Project? Think of it as a folder that remembers. You write your business down once — who you are, what you sell, who buys it, how you sound — and every chat you start inside that folder already knows all of it. You never explain yourself again. That's all a Project is: a folder, plus the notes you put in it.

E7 — Build "My Business Brain"

Goal: write your business down once, so every chat you start from now on already knows it.

Steps

1. Click in your browser's **address bar** at the very top of the screen, type **claude.ai/projects**, and press Enter. (Or move your mouse to the left sidebar and click **Projects**.)
2. Click **" + New Project "** in the **upper right**.
3. Name it **My Business Brain**. For the description, something like: *Everything Claude needs to know about my shop*.
4. Find the field labeled **"Set project instructions."** This is the important box. Whatever you put in here, Claude reads before every single chat you start inside this project. Think of it as the job description.
5. Type the template below into that box. Replace everything inside [SQUARE BRACKETS] with your own words — and delete the brackets when you do. Keep the rest of the wording as it is:

```
I own [BUSINESS NAME], a [KIND OF BUSINESS] in [CITY, STATE].  
We sell: [THE 3-5 THINGS THAT MAKE YOU MOST OF YOUR MONEY]  
Our customers are: [WHO ACTUALLY BUYS FROM YOU]  
Busy times: [SEASONS, DAYS, EVENTS]  
Our voice sounds like: [THREE WORDS] – for example: "[ONE SENTENCE THE WAY  
YOU'D ACTUALLY SAY IT OUT LOUD]"  
Never say: [WORDS, CLAIMS, OR PROMISES YOU DON'T MAKE]  
When I ask for writing, default to [LENGTH / FORMAT].  
If you need something you don't have, ask me instead of guessing.
```

6. Save it.

Don't overthink the wording. You can edit this forever, and you will. If a bracket is still unfilled when time is called, put something rough in it and move on — you can fix it tonight.

The two lines everybody skips are "Our voice sounds like" and "Never say." Those two are exactly what stop the writing from sounding like a robot. For the voice line, don't describe it — write one sentence the way you'd actually say it out loud to a customer, and put that in the quotes.

Done when: a project named My Business Brain exists in your account and the "Set project instructions" box has your business in it, with no square brackets left.

Fast finisher: A project can hold files too. That's called the project's **knowledge** — files you park in the project itself, which Claude uses as background for *every* chat you start in there, instead of you re-attaching them every time.

Upload one real file into the project's knowledge — your price list, your service menu, your FAQ. Add it from your **My Business Brain** project page, where files get attached to the project itself. (That's a different thing from the + button inside a chat's message box — that one attaches a file to a single message only.) Each file can be up to 30MB. Then start a chat and ask it something that requires that file, like *what do we charge for X?*

E8 — Stress-test it

Goal: watch it answer a lazy question well, because it finally knows who you are.

Steps

1. Make sure you're **inside your project**, not out in a regular chat. This is the one that trips everybody: your project instructions only apply to chats you start from inside the project.
2. Start your new chat **from that project page** — not from the **New chat** button in the sidebar, which drops you into a regular chat *outside* the project. If you're not certain you're in the right place, click in your address bar, type **claude.ai/projects**, press Enter, click **My Business Brain**, and start your chat from that page. Check that **My Business Brain** is still showing on screen before you type.
3. Ask three things you'd normally have to explain yourself for first. Type them bare — no setup, no background, no context. For example:
 - *Write a post for this weekend.*
 - *What should I say to a customer who's unhappy about a late order?*
 - *Give me three ideas for September.*
4. After each answer, stop and notice one thing it got right that you never typed — your town, your hours, the way you talk about what you sell. That gap between what you asked and what it knew is the whole point of Block 4.
5. Spot something it got wrong about you? That's not a failure — that's a missing line. Go back to **"Set project instructions"** and add it.

Done when: you've asked three bare questions inside your project and the answers came back sounding like your business instead of like a stranger's.

Fast finisher: Ask it: *based on my project instructions, what else should I tell you about my business that would make your answers better?* Then add its best suggestion to the instructions.

Three habits to take home

Everything you did today comes down to three habits. Not twenty tips — three.

Give it context. Iterate out loud. Show it an example.

- **Give it context.** That's E1 and E7 — the difference between "write a post about Mother's Day" and telling it who you are, what town you're in, and what you sound like. Nine times out of ten, a bad answer is a context problem.
- **Iterate out loud.** That's E2. Don't accept the first draft and don't start over. Just say what's wrong with it, in plain words.
- **Show it an example.** Nobody does this one and it's the strongest of the three. Paste in a post that worked. Say "more like this." Describing what you want is hard; showing what you want is easy.

If something goes sideways

What's happening	What to do
Can't find the + button	It's in the lower-left corner of the message box , not the top of the screen, and it's not a paperclip. Or just drag the file into the chat window.
No chart appeared	The setting. Initials (bottom-left) → Settings → Capabilities → turn on " Code execution and file creation " → ask for the chart again.
"It won't take my file"	Usually an Excel .xlsx, which needs that same setting on. Fastest fix: upload the CSV version instead.
"It says I can't make another project"	You've hit the project limit on your account. Delete a project you're not using and try again.
Your project doesn't seem to know you	You're probably in a regular chat. Go to claude.ai/projects , open My Business Brain , and start the chat from in there.
"Where did my chat go?"	Left sidebar — your conversations are listed there, and your charts are under Artifacts . Nothing gets deleted just because you clicked away.
It said something that isn't true	It can be wrong, in a confident voice. That's why you're still the boss. Ask it to quote the exact section of the file it's using.
You're behind	You're not. Every step is written out in here, and this packet is yours to keep. Finish it tonight in your kitchen.

Keep this packet. Everything in it works exactly the same way at your desk next week as it did in this room today. If you ever lose track of it, this packet, the cheat sheet, and the homework are all downloadable at **tinyurl.com/petalstem26** — the same link the sample files came from. The homework is three small things before August 20.